

The Six-Week Launch Checklist

From contract to first guest, week by week. Companion to Chapter 13 of Vacation Rentals That Pay You. Print it, tape it to the wall, check the boxes.

The Timing Rules (read these first)

- **The target: keys in hand to listing live in six weeks.** Block six weeks on your calendar post-close, **plus a buffer**. If something slips a week, you don't miss your launch window.
 - **The clock starts before closing.** Escrow is prep time, not waiting time. Everything in Phase 0 below happens while you're under contract.
 - **Best case:** a reno-light home can compress to about **one week** — keys, install, staging, photos.
 - **Worst case:** a botched fixer can stretch a few-week setup into **four months** and eat a third of your year. This is why structural changes are never worth the timeline delays. Skip them.
 - **Photos are the gate.** The shoot happens in week 3 or 4, not week 6. Everything downstream waits on it, so schedule the photographer before you think you're ready.
 - **Speed is the point.** Every empty night is your biggest cost. Perception beats perfection.
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Phase 0 — Under Contract (Before You Close)

- ☐ **Line up contractor bids.** Paint, flooring, handyman work — bids in hand so work begins Day 1 after closing.
- ☐ **Complete your inspections** inside the contingency period.
- ☐ **Get a bindable STR insurance quote before your inspection contingency expires.** A quote you could accept on the spot, not a website estimate. Homeowners policies void the moment you host; a rural cabin with a hot tub often quotes \$2,500-\$6,000 a year. A high premium eats the deal's cushion — know the number before you're locked in.
- ☐ **Pre-schedule utilities, internet, and insurance.** Set start dates for electric, water, WiFi, and the STR policy to activate right after closing.
- ☐ **Create a project calendar.** Block the first six weeks post-close plus a buffer. Plan the order: light reno → furniture install → photos → listing → launch.
- ☐ **Prep your furniture financing.** For many hosts that's a 0% intro-APR card — **but only if you'll clear it inside the intro window. A bridge, not a balance.** Chapter 7's rules apply.
- ☐ **Load the furniture carts — but do not order anything until you own the home.** Deals fall through.

Closing Day

- ☐ **Hit “order” on the major furniture pieces** the moment you close. Deliver to the property or a storage unit.
 - ☐ **Confirm utilities, internet, and STR insurance are active.**
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Weeks 1–2 — Contractor Work and Light Reno

- ☐ Contractor work and inspections underway from Day 1.
- ☐ Light reno only: **paint and fixtures**. Splurge where it shows on camera — beds, lighting, paint, art and décor. Skip full remodels, luxury flooring, high-end appliances, and anything structural.
- ☐ Pre-order any remaining major furniture (mattresses \$300–\$500 per bed; linens and pillows \$200–\$300 per bed — comfort drives reviews).
- ☐ Quick wins as budget allows: swapped light fixtures, peel-and-stick backsplash, oversized art or mirrors, front-door and outdoor-lighting refresh, fire pit.
- ☐ Start lining up your boots-on-the-ground team: **your first cleaner is your most important hire — treat them like a partner**. Also: a handyman, lawn or snow care.

Weeks 2–3 — Furniture Install and Styling

- ☐ Furniture delivery and installation.
- ☐ Interior styling and décor. Design for photos first, comfort second. Maximize sleepers per room (bunks, trundles, pull-out sofas) — sleeping capacity is revenue.
- ☐ **Hire the photographer if you haven’t**. The shoot is the gate for everything downstream.
- ☐ Create a detailed inventory checklist.
- ☐ If you hired design help: approve mood boards and picks within 24 hours. You are the bottleneck if you let yourself be.

Weeks 3–4 — Photography and Systems

- ☐ **Professional photography shoot**. No other line item earns back more per dollar.
- ☐ Set up your systems:
 - ☐ Messaging automation (Hospitable)
 - ☐ Pricing tool (PriceLabs)
 - ☐ Security hardware: smart lock with unique per-guest codes, exterior camera only — indoor cameras never
- ☐ **Create the listing on Airbnb.**

Weeks 4–5 — Listing Build and Pricing Ladder

- ☐ Fine-tune the listing: hero photos, title, description.
- ☐ Lead with what's unique and searchable ("Hot Tub | Fire Pit | Minutes to Hiking"), not bed counts.
- ☐ Sell the dream in the first five lines; save beds and kitchen features for later.
- ☐ 30–50 high-quality photos. If you paid thousands for it, it's in the first five photos and the title.
- ☐ Set launch pricing and calendar rules:
 - ☐ Launch price **15–20% below comps** (the Pricing Ladder assumes the full 20%)
 - ☐ 3-night minimum
 - ☐ Instant Book on from day one
 - ☐ Plan the ladder now: 20% under at launch → 10% under in weeks 3–4 → market rate by month 2 → 5–10% over by months 3–6 once your rating is 4.8+
- ☐ **Pre-list to build early algorithm interest.** Listing live, calendar closed; send the link to friends and followers to wishlist it.
- ☐ List on both Airbnb and Vrbo.
- ☐ Confirm cleaner, handyman, and a short local vendor list (plumber, electrician, HVAC) are ready.

Week 6 — Launch

- ☐ **Go live.** Open the calendar and start accepting bookings.
- ☐ Monitor messages closely — respond within 15 minutes during the first two weeks; under an hour is a ranking factor.
- ☐ Prepare for first guests: ultra-clear instructions, thoughtful touches (firewood, local treats, a handwritten note).

After Go-Live — The First Month

- ☐ Answer every message fast, personally at first; automate warm replies once patterns emerge.
 - ☐ Climb the Pricing Ladder on schedule; update base price and rules every 2–4 weeks, watch trends weekly.
 - ☐ **Collect your first 3–5 reviews.** They make or break early ranking. Fix problems fast, pair the fix with a small gesture, and send a short follow-up after checkout asking for the review.
 - ☐ Set up bookkeeping from day one: revenue, operating expenses, cap-ex, loan payments, and a receipt system. Clean books equal clean tax write-offs.
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That first booking notification is execution, not luck. None of it reaches the bank until you launch.